

What's happening now?

Two rovers, *Spirit* and *Opportunity*, have been exploring the Martian surface since 2004. They have sent back a wealth of data about the planet's surface, including plenty of evidence that there was once water on Mars.

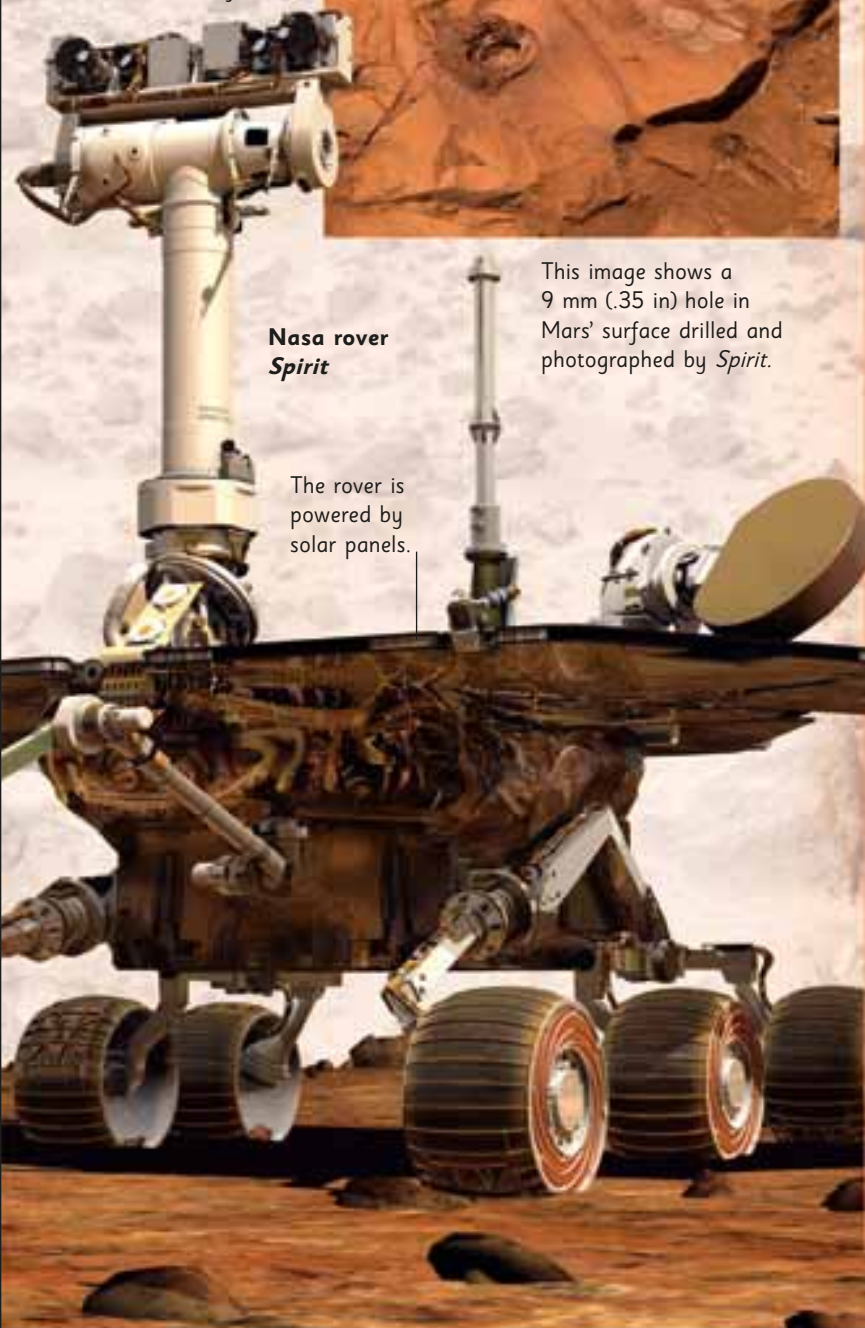
Cameras mounted on masts give scientists panoramic views of the Martian surface.



This image shows a 9 mm (.35 in) hole in Mars' surface drilled and photographed by *Spirit*.

Nasa rover *Spirit*

The rover is powered by solar panels.



The future on Mars



Scientists are always searching for ways to unlock the secrets of the red planet. Among the ideas suggested are an aeroplane that could travel across its surface (above left) and a thermal probe that would penetrate its ice caps (above right).



In order to explore the potential of a colony in space, eight scientists lived in a self-contained dome, *Biosphere II*, for two years during the early 1990s.

Living on Mars

If we do establish a base on Mars, it will have to be a self-contained structure that protects its inhabitants from both the atmosphere and the Sun's radiation.

Below is an artist's impression of what a Martian base might look like.

